of the Koran, and then were taught grammar, Islamic law, logic, mathematics, and some elements of medicine. At the same time, calligraphic skills were developed, as an elegant hand was considered an essential skill. Akbar's thoughts on education were quite clearly elucidated by Abu'l Fazl:

> A great portion of the life of the students is wasted by making them read many books. His majesty orders that every schoolboy should first learn to write the letters of the alphabet, and also learn to trace their several forms. He ought to learn the shape and the name of each letter, which may be done in two days, when the boy should proceed to write the joined letters.

After learning writing skills the emphasis was on comprehension of the material, with the teacher only there to direct the pupil. The princes were encouraged to read books that dealt with morals, arithmetic, accountancy, agriculture, mensuration, geometry, astronomy, physiognomy, household matters, rules of government, medicine, logic, physical sciences, sciences, spiritual sciences, and history.

At the same time, young mirzas and amirs began their training in the martial skills at the age of nine. They would acquire skills in archery, horsemanship, and wrestling. Progressively harder training increased endurance and instilled competitiveness. Wrestling was a very developed art, with masters teaching their charges special tricks 'to overcome deficiencies in weight or height'. Training in hand-to-hand combat taught the young men how to defend against dagger attacks; they were even shown how to disarm an opponent with a handkerchief.

The careful and unremitting attention paid to the education of princes and children of nobility, was by no means usual in other parts of the world at this time. A full century later, when Peter the Great began his education in Russia in 1675 at the age of three, he was simply handed a primer to learn the alphabet. 'At that time in Muscovy,' writes the biographer Robert K. Massie, 'most people, even among the gentry and the clergy, were illiterate. In the nobility, education rarely consisted of more than reading, writing and a smattering of history, and geography.' The Mughals' reverence for education and learning was part of their Timurid ancestry, which valued a cultured and aesthetic sensibility as highly as military accomplishments. As we know, Salim's great-grandfather Babur wrote a